

[Un]Focused

Struggle is something everyone has to deal with everyday. Whether it be from uncontrollable circumstances, or existing limitations. What if you had to struggle even with simple tasks? What if, despite your constant effort, you could not be “normal” like the other around you? It is overwhelming, demoralizing, and crushing. That is exactly how I feel everyday, in a system that was not built for people like me. That is the reason my code poem *[Un]Focused* came into being. It is my attempt at expressing what my life is like everyday, and to show people that from the outside I may seem impulsive or lazy, but in reality I am constantly being dragged down by my own brain's biology. I hope to allow a window into my life for people to understand what it is like to live with ADHD, and executive functioning struggles.

My inspiration was primarily sourced from Bertram's Travesty Generator, specifically the last-three-words poem. I use the limitation of the computer and play on memory allocation issues. This idea of using technical limitations as expressions led me to form the initial idea for *[Un]Focused*. I wanted to use this idea to reproduce what it is like to deal with an executive function issue, using terms like “thoughts” or “struggles”. Eventually it turned into technical terms such as “memory allocated” and “abandoned”. I wanted to convert my mind into a computation, just as Bertram had within their code poem. This express abuse of computational resources was hard to accomplish as Bertram had in their work, so I simulated this overwhelm using terminology that would be found in process interruptions, and allowed for some AI guidance to help me realize my goal. Bertram's work within code as a "constraint" was the perfect landscape to explore my idea, and allow me to pour my soul into the code and its output.

The idea that Bertram's work instilled into was: How can I use the code to portray my struggles, using code as a “constraint”? The answer I found was to use failed processes as a throughline in my experience. People everyday get the spinning beach ball on mac computers, or the blue screen on windows machines. Additionally programmers see process interrupts, or failures all the time. These every day occurrences pushed me to apply this logic to mapping my own struggles into code. I used code to show the interruptions my mind experiences every single day, and how sometimes they can cascade overwhelming me. Just as a computer can run into glitches, so can the human mind, especially those considered neurodivergent. People like me struggle to accomplish the day to day activities most people take for granted and do easily. But what if your mind was a collection of failed and abandoned processes? What if you could barely remember to eat let alone track deadlines? That is exactly what my poem seeks to illustrate, I want to show just how hard it is for me to live life “normally”.

This poem offered a unique opportunity to look inwards towards myself. I had convinced myself that I was ok with being different, that I was ok the system wasn't made for people like me. After writing this poem I realized I'm not ok with the status quo. Just because you are wired differently than others, doesn't mean the world shouldn't change to help you succeed. Instead the world just offers “accommodation” only seeking to provide the bare minimum so people like me can't say they didn't try. *[Un]Focused* seeks to bridge the gap, people don't change because they are told to. They change with experience, with understanding, and with empathy. I want to

provide a means in which they can try to understand the struggle. I hope that my small work accomplishes just a little of this goal, and that my experience is truly seen through my code.